WARS OF INDEPENDENCE

AT THE START of the 19th century, South America was under the rule of Spain and Portugal. Between 1810 and 1826 a series of wars was fought that resulted in independence for these colonies, which then fought wars among themselves to define their new borders. Although the land campaigns of Simón Bolívar and José de San Martín played the leading part in the wars of independence against Spain, naval warfare also had a significant impact. The makeshift forces of the republican rebels performed remarkably well against the Spanish navy, but imported expertise was essential to their success. Maverick British admiral Thomas Cochrane became a hero of the independence struggle in Chile and Peru, while a previously undistinguished Irish sea captain, William Brown, earned legendary status in Argentina for his exploits both before and after independence. The battle of Lake Maracaibo was the final decisive victory in the struggle for the independence of Colombia, which briefly comprised also Venezuela and Ecuador. The Argentinian defeat at Monte Santiago was a key step toward the foundation of Uruguay as a separate country.

URUGUAYAN WAR OF INDEPENDENCE

MONTEVIDEO



Date May 14–17, 1814
Forces Argentinians: 10 ships; Spanish: 13 ships
Losses Argentinians: 1 ship sunk; Spanish: 2 ships sunk, 5 captured

Location Off Montevideo, Uruguay

In 1814 the Argentinians, engaged in an independence war against Spain, decided they needed a naval force to contest Spanish dominance at sea. William Brown, an Irish-born seaman who had recently settled in Argentina, was placed in command of the fledgling navy. He assembled a force of seven ships, taking as his flagship the frigate *Hercules*. The Argentine navy was blooded on March 8 in an attack upon Isla Martin Garcia, a Spanish stronghold in the mouth of the River Uruguay. Brown then established a blockade of Montevideo, his naval force augmented by three armed merchant ships. A Spanish squadron was in the harbor, protected by shore batteries. In mid-May, Brown pretended to lift the blockade, luring the Spanish ships into setting to sea, where he forced them to give battle. The fiercest engagement occurred on May 16. Brown had his leg shattered by a cannonball, but his squadron got by far the better of the fight. As a result of this naval victory, Argentina was able to take control of Montevideo.

CHILEAN WAR OF INDEPENDENCE

VALDIVIA



Date February 3–4, 1820
Forces Chileans: 1 ship; Spanish: c.1600men
Losses Chileans: 7 killed; Spanish: 100 killed

Location Corral Bay, Chile

In Chile's War of Independence against Spain, British admiral Sir Thomas Cochrane commanded the Chilean fleet in dashing style. He was convinced that the Spanish forces would crumble if subjected to unremitting aggression. Valdivia was the best defended Spanish stronghold in Chile – it had been compared to Gibraltar. Corral Bay, the approach to Valdivia from the sea, was protected by forts and other strongpoints mounting some 120 guns and manned by around 1,600 soldiers. Cochrane, with little over 300 men under his command and a leaky frigate *O'Higgins* as his sole effective warship, decided to take Valdivia by a nighttime amphibious assault. Achieving complete surprise, the Chileans landed in the darkness and attacked Fort Ingles, which was swiftly abandoned by its garrison. In the confusion Cochrane's men mingled with Spanish soldiers, compounding the problems of Spanish officers attempting to organize resistance. By the end of the night the four forts on the south side of the bay were in Cochrane's hands. Utterly demoralized, Valdivia itself surrendered shortly afterward.

Valdivian fort system
These extensive fortifications protected a port used by ships crossing the Straits of Magellan.



1775–1860

THOMAS COCHRANE

BRITISH COMMANDER OF THE CHILEAN FLEET IN THE CHILEAN WAR OF INDEPENDENCE

Serving in the Napoleonic Wars, Thomas Cochrane, Earl of Dundonald, made his name through bold exploits as a captain of sloops and frigates. His progress in his naval career was inhibited by his involvement in politics and criticism of corruption in high places. In 1814 he was disgraced for alleged involvement in stock market fraud. After a spell in prison, he sought employment abroad, serving in independence wars in Chile, Brazil, and Greece.



VENEZUELAN WAR OF INDEPENDENCE

LAKE MARACAIBO



Date July 24,1823
Forces Colombians: 22 ships; Spanish: 32 ships
Losses Unknown

Location Lake Maracaibo, Venezuela

Despite the victories of Simón Bolívar, in 1823 the independence of Colombia was still contested by Spain. Spanish forces were holding the key town of Maracaibo, by the eponymous salt-water lake. José Prudencio Padilla, commander of a Colombian naval force comprising a corvette, three brigantines, and a variety of small vessels, entered the lake from the Gulf of Venezuela to attack Maracaibo. Crossing the bar into the lake under the Spanish guns of Fort San Carlos, one of Padilla's ships was destroyed after running aground. The Spanish sent a squadron under Angel Laborde into the lake to pursue Padilla. On July 24, in a fierce close-quarters mêlée fought more with machetes than with cannon, the Spanish were defeated despite superior numbers. Maracaibo was recaptured and Spanish forces in Colombia laid down their arms.

ARGENTINA-BRAZIL WAR

MONTE SANTIAGO



Date April 7-8,1827
Forces Brazilians: c.14 ships; Argentinians: 4 ships
Losses Brazilians: none; Argentinians: 2 ships lost

Location Off coast of Argentina

In the war between Brazil and the United Provinces (Argentina and Uruguay) in 1825–28, the Argentinians had a naval squadron of small warships. Brazil had a far larger navy, but it was timidly led. Argentinian commander Admiral William Brown defeated a Brazilian river flotilla at Juncal in February 1827. The following April he took the brigs *Republic Argentina* and *Independencia*, plus a corvette and a schooner, out of his base at Los Pozos, evading a Brazilian blockade by hugging the coast (the Brazilian ships could not operate in the shallows). But Brown's two brigs ran aground. Captain James Norton, commanding the Brazilian blockade squadron, brought in four shallow-draft schooners and had a frigate towed into range to bombard the grounded ships. After a hard fight they were destroyed. Brown's other two ships escaped with heavy damage.